



AUTISM IN RUGBY

Resource 2

A Neurodiverse Sport Publication produced
in collaboration with England Rugby

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NdS
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Autism in Rugby

This resource is the second in a series aimed at deepening your understanding of neurodiversity in rugby and building practical neuroinclusive coaching skills.

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For the best foundation, we recommend reading the resources in sequence. Together, they support coaches, players, and the community in creating environments where both neurodivergent and neurotypical individuals can thrive. Neuroinclusive practices benefit everyone on and off the field.



PART 1

AN INTRODUCTION TO AUTISM

A Distinct Combination of Characteristics

Autism is diagnosed based on a distinct combination of characteristics, including differences in social communication and interaction, sensory and emotional processing, a preference for routine, and often highly specialised interests. These traits shape an individual's unique experience of the world and contribute to the diversity within autism.

Autism is considered a heterogeneous condition because it manifests in a wide variety of ways across individuals.

A Heterogeneous Condition

While autism has a strong genetic basis, the specific genetic factors vary widely, with hundreds of genes and mutations contributing differently to its manifestation. This variability extends to traits, intensity, associated conditions, and underlying biological mechanisms. For example, autism can coexist with learning disabilities, but most autistic individuals possess average or above-average intelligence, often referred to as 'high-functioning autism.'



EACH INDIVIDUAL IS UNIQUE

Autism is a diverse spectrum, encompassing a wide range of experiences and support needs. While some autistic individuals would benefit from participating in specialist sports programmes, the majority of autistic people will participate in mainstream sport, requiring minimal adjustment.

It is crucial to recognise each autistic person as unique, with their own challenges, strengths, and ways of experiencing the world.



Language

Person First or Identity First?

The choice between "person with autism" and "autistic person" depends on individual and community preferences, highlighting the importance of asking each person what they prefer. "Person with autism," a form of person-first language, is commonly used in medical and educational contexts to emphasise the individual before the condition. Conversely, "autistic person," an identity-first approach, is favoured by many within the autistic community—particularly self-advocates—because it affirms autism as an integral part of their identity.

The choice between "person with autism" and "autistic person" depends on individual and community preferences.

PART 2

MYTH-BUSTING FACTS ABOUT AUTISM IN RUGBY

The complexity of autism as a spectrum condition is frequently oversimplified, while outdated medical perspectives and deficit-focused research have further fuelled stigma. To challenge these misconceptions, we need ongoing education, more accurate and diverse representation, and a deeper, more nuanced understanding of autism. Let's start by busting some common myths!

Myth 1

Myth

Autism is only a limitation rather than a potential source of strength.

Fact

Autism is a spectrum, and traits associated with it—such as attention to detail, strategic thinking, and a strong sense of fairness—can be powerful strengths.

In Rugby

An autistic athlete might excel in analysing plays, anticipating opponents' moves, or mastering technical skills. Their unique perspective can offer creative solutions to challenges on and off the pitch.



Myth 2

Myth

Autistic people aren't social and don't enjoy being part of a team.

Fact

Autistic individuals often value connection but may prefer different styles of communication or interaction.

In Rugby

While traditional team-building exercises might feel overwhelming, autistic players can thrive in team environments that value clear communication, mutual respect, and diverse contributions. When supported appropriately, they can form strong bonds with teammates and play a crucial role in team dynamics.

Myth 3

Myth

Autistic people can't handle competitive or high-pressure situations.

Fact

Many autistic individuals excel under pressure, especially when they have clear strategies and routines to rely on.

In Rugby

Their ability to hyperfocus and remain dedicated to their passions can lead to exceptional performance in their chosen sport. Structured training plans and consistent game-day routines can help them navigate competition with confidence and resilience.



PART 3

AUTISTIC STRENGTHS AND CHALLENGES

Remember, autism manifests uniquely, so each person will experience a distinct combination of the following strengths and challenges.

AREA	STRENGTHS	CHALLENGES
Social Communication and Interaction	Strong preference for direct and honest communication, which can foster clarity and avoid ambiguity.	Difficulty interpreting social cues, such as tone of voice or facial expressions, leading to misunderstandings.
	Ability to focus on the content of conversations rather than being influenced by social expectations or conventions.	Challenges in understanding and expressing emotions, potentially causing difficulties in building relationships.
	Often excels in environments where clear, structured and consistent communication is valued.	Finding nuance or implied meanings confusing, which can make indirect communication difficult.
Repetitive Behaviours and Routines	Highly dependable in following structured processes, routines schedules, and established guidelines.	Reliance on routines to manage anxiety, which can make adapting to changes or unpredictability challenging.
	Repetitive behaviours can serve as effective coping mechanisms, improving focus and calmness.	Repetitive movements or vocalisations that are essential for self-regulation, may be misunderstood by others.
	Deep expertise and passion in areas of interest, often excelling in fields or tasks requiring attention to detail.	Intense focus on specific interests or activities, which can lead to over-prioritising at the expense of other tasks.



AUTISTIC STRENGTHS AND CHALLENGES CONTINUED...

AREA	STRENGTHS	CHALLENGES
Sensory Processing Differences	Exceptional awareness of sensory details that others might overlook, such as subtle changes in sound or texture.	Potential heightened sensitivity to sensory inputs, such as being overwhelmed by loud noises, bright lights, or textures.
	Seeking specific sensory inputs can enhance focus and productivity, such as listening to music while working.	Potential reduced sensitivity to sensory inputs, which can lead to missing sensory cues that others easily detect.
	Creative use of sensory preferences to find comfort and enhance performance in different settings.	Atypical responses to sensory experiences, which may appear intense or unusual to others.
Cognitive and Emotional Processing	Strong pattern recognition and attention to detail, which can lead to innovative and adaptive problem-solving.	Difficulty regulating emotions, sometimes leading to intense meltdowns or shutdowns in stressful situations.
	Analytical thinking that enables unique, innovative, and practical perspectives on complex problems.	Challenges in recognising or articulating emotions, which may lead to confusion or frustration.
Flexibility of Thought	Preference for structure allows for precise planning, reliable implementation, and consistent execution of tasks.	Difficulty adapting to unexpected changes or shifting focus between tasks, which can increase stress and anxiety.
	Ability to perform and thrive in predictable, structured environments where rules are codified.	Resistance to ambiguity, often needing detailed instructions, clear expectations, and defined outcomes.

SUCCESSFUL AUTISTIC ATHLETES

Here are some examples of successful autistic athletes who have excelled in their respective fields, demonstrating the potential strength of autism in providing providing unique perspectives, exceptional focus, and innovative problem-solving skills.

UK-Based

- **Aliyah Zaranyika** – Professional Super League netball player, England, 2022–present
- **Greg Halford** – Former Premier League footballer, England, 2003–2022
- **Jessica Jane Applegate** – Paralympic swimmer, Great Britain, 2011–present
- **Kyle Trout** – Professional rugby league player, England, 2011–present
- **Olivia Rae** – Scottish international cricketer, Scotland, 2009–2021
- **Samantha Smith** – Former British No. 1 tennis player, Great Britain, 1990–2000
- **Sarah Hope** – GB Para Ice Hockey and GB wheelchair basketball player, Great Britain, 2015–present
- **Tom Stoltman** – Two-time World’s Strongest Man, Scotland, 2019–present

International Highlights

- **Chris Morgan** – World champion and Olympic rower, Australia, 2004–2016
- **Clay Marzo** – World-renowned professional surfer, USA, 2005–present



PART 4

REDUCING CHALLENGES, LEVERAGE STRENGTHS

Supporting an autistic person in a sports setting involves creating an environment where challenges are minimised and strengths are celebrated.

AUTISM: REDUCING CHALLENGES

Provide Clear Communication

Provide clear written or visual supports alongside verbal instructions, ensuring language is direct and unambiguous.



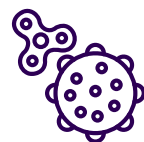
Ensure Predictability and Routine

Establish consistent training schedules and routines, and inform the individual of any changes in advance.



Offer Sensory Adjustments

Create sensory-friendly spaces, limiting exposure to bright lights, loud noises, or strong smells.



Encourage Social Inclusion

Foster an understanding and supportive team culture, using interest-driven activities to encourage positive interactions.



Support Emotional Regulation

Normalise the use of emotional supports, and recognise the signs of overwhelm, offering time-outs when needed



AUTISM: LEVERAGING STRENGTHS

Leverage Attention to Detail

Assign roles or tasks that benefit from precision, such as analysing plays or observing opponents.



Nurture Focus and Dedication

Encourage their deep interest in the sport, potentially using it as a motivator for learning new skills.



Harness Strategic Thinking

Allow them to contribute to game plans or tactics where pattern recognition and strategic insight can shine.



Channel Reliability in Routine

Utilise their preference for consistency to strengthen team drills and adherence to practise schedules.



Champion Unique Perspectives

Value their fresh ideas or unconventional approaches to problem-solving in gameplay or training strategies.



AUTISM: BUILDING CONFIDENCE

Offer Constructive Feedback

Provide regular, specific, and constructive feedback that emphasises progress and contributions.



Celebrate Success

Celebrate successes and highlight how unique traits and perspectives benefit the team.



YOU CAN ENABLE

By combining understanding, adjustments, and appreciation, you can enable autistic individuals to contribute meaningfully to the team while enjoying personal growth, ultimately thriving in sports settings.



PART 5

CASE STUDY - SUPPORT IN ACTION

SAM'S JOURNEY AS AN AUTISTIC RUGBY PLAYER

Background

Sam, a 20-year-old player with exceptional talent and dedication to rugby, faced significant challenges in group settings. While his coach admired his skills and determination, they struggled to understand or support the unique difficulties he experienced. Unaware that Sam was autistic—and unfamiliar with how autism manifests differently in everyone—the coach misinterpreted his behaviours, such as becoming overwhelmed during training sessions and withdrawing from drills, as disruptive behaviour.

Lacking insight into the root cause of Sam's challenges, the coach was unable to provide the tailored support he needed to thrive.

Sam, a player with exceptional talent and dedication to rugby, faced significant challenges in group settings.



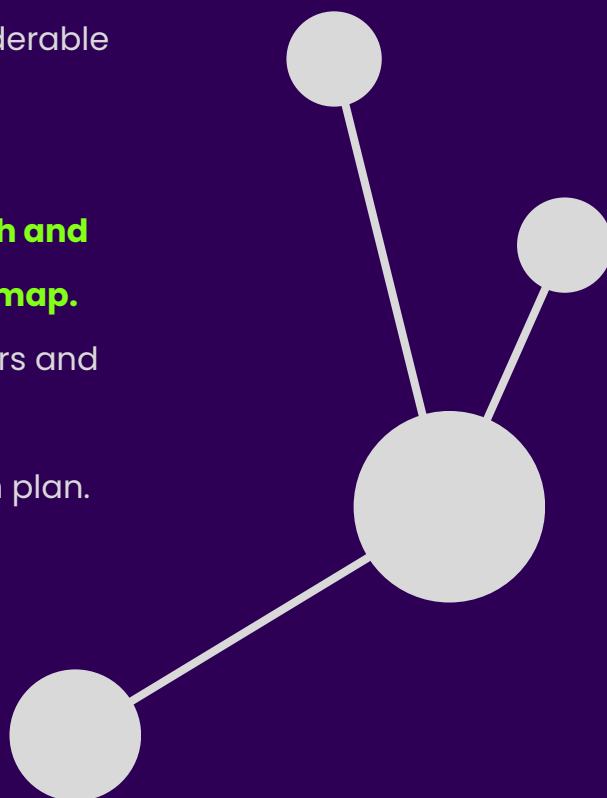
The Turning Point

To better support Sam, the coach arranged a facilitated conversation with him and an advocate of his choice. Initially hesitant to disclose his diagnosis, Sam feared being defined by a label. However, **with the support of a friend, he decided to share his diagnosis with the coach.** Together, they explored how Sam's unique traits influenced his experience in a rugby setting. They identified sensory sensitivities as a significant challenge in group environments, with triggers like the sharp sound of whistles, the chaotic nature of group drills, and the texture of certain training gear causing Sam considerable discomfort.

As part of this learning process, **the coach and Sam collaborated to develop a sensory map.**

This map outlined specific sensory triggers and strategies to address them, forming the cornerstone of a tailored communication plan.

They discovered that sensory sensitivities were significant contributors to his struggles in group settings.



Support in Action

Armed with this sensory map and overall **communication plan**, the coach implemented accommodations to enable Sam to stay regulated and thrive. For instance:

Sam agreed to review his strategies every two months, recognising that needs and preferences can evolve over time.

➡ Managing Sensory Sensitivities

Adjustments were made, such as using visual cues instead of loud whistles and allowing Sam to wear preferred kit that minimised discomfort.

➡ Communication Strategies

Clear, direct instructions were provided, often in advance, to reduce unpredictability and anxiety during group drills.

➡ Empowerment

Sam was encouraged to identify and communicate her needs, fostering self-awareness and self-advocacy.



Growth and Development

At 22, **Sam has flourished both on and off the pitch.** Through these tailored interventions, he has developed his own self-support strategies and grown more confident in managing his sensory sensitivities. He has also made significant strides in self-advocacy, with his coach playing a key role in creating a safe and supportive environment for Sam to express his needs.

His ability to communicate effectively has matured alongside his skills in rugby, allowing him to thrive in both individual and group settings.

Sam now feels comfortable speaking up if a training exercise becomes overwhelming and suggesting alternatives that work for him.



Conclusion

The Power of Inclusivity

By providing tailored support and empowering Sam to self-advocate, the coach not only facilitated Sam's success in rugby but also contributed to his personal development. This example highlights how understanding, flexibility, and accommodations in sport can transform potential barriers into opportunities for achievement, reinforcing the power of inclusivity and support in helping autistic athletes succeed both on and off the field.



A Neurodiverse Sport Publication produced
in collaboration with England Rugby

With thanks to

the following members of the Neurodiverse Sport team

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and the following members of the Rugby Community

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Ali Boyd	Joanna Perkins	Rebecca Shea
Andy Rutherford	John Smith	Stacey Sewell
Charlotte Lloyd	Lindsey Chaplin	Stephen Garrett
Chris Spedding	Luke Cheyne	Tanya Bird
Dan Field	Lynsey Hyslop	Tim Pickard
Grant Hathaway	Mark Finnis	Tom Kidd



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